The Last Light of Saltmere

The storm hit the Silver Gull just after sunset. Waves crashed over the wooden deck, the sails snapped in the wind and thunder rolled across a purple sky. Captain Mara, a young pirate with a red bandana, held the helm while her little pug Biscuit barked at every flash of lightning. Old Finn, the ship's cook, ran up from the galley holding a wet scroll he had found inside a floating bottle. "Captain, read this!" he shouted. The scroll was a torn map, signed by the keeper of the Saltmere lighthouse: "The light has gone out. Without it, every ship on this coast will sink. Find the Sun Crystal and bring it home." Mara rang the ship's brass bell three times and turned the wheel towards the dark shore.

The Silver Gull reached a quiet beach under a sky full of stars. Broken barrels and old nets lay on the white sand, and a cold wind blew between the palm trees. Next to a small wooden hut, an old woman in a long dark coat was waiting with an unlit lantern. She was Agnes, the lighthouse keeper. "A sea witch stole the Sun Crystal and hid it under the waves," she said sadly. "Take this lantern. When you light it with the fire of my hearth, it will show you the way through the deep." Mara picked up the lantern and lit it in the campfire, and it began to glow with a soft blue light. Biscuit ran along the shore, barking at the waves, and Agnes pointed at the black water beyond the rocks: "That is where the sunken city sleeps."

Mara dived into the sea holding the blue lantern. Below the surface, a sunken city opened in front of her: broken stone columns covered in coral, green seaweed dancing in the current and schools of bright fish swimming between the ruins. In the middle of a ruined temple stood Morwen, the sea witch, with a pointed hat and glowing eyes. "Nobody leaves my kingdom without answering my riddle," she said with a smile. "What has a face but no eyes, and hands but cannot hold?" Mara thought for a moment and answered: "A clock." The witch laughed, and the coral around the temple began to shine with magic. "Clever girl. The crystal is in the cave of the goblin king, at the end of the coral path." On a stone altar, an ancient inscription warned: "Only the brave may wake the sun."

The underwater path ended inside a dark cave full of stalactites and glowing purple mushrooms. Gold coins and treasure chests were piled everywhere, and in the deepest corner a small goblin king sat on a throne made of bones, guarding an enormous locked chest. "Thieves! Thieves in my cave!" he screamed, and jumped on his throne. Near the entrance, half hidden among the coins, Mara found a big pink seashell that sang softly when the wind passed through it. She picked it up, bowed politely and offered it to the goblin king. He held it to his ear, heard the song of the sea and started to dance with joy. "Fine, fine! Take the key, but do not touch my gold!" he said, and threw a rusty iron key at her feet. Mara picked up the key and opened the big chest, and a warm golden light filled the whole cave. Inside, the Sun Crystal was shining like a small sun.

At dawn, Mara climbed the long stone stairs of the Saltmere lighthouse on top of the cliff, with Biscuit running ahead of her. At the top, Agnes the keeper waited next to the giant empty lamp, surrounded by old books and maps of the coast. On a small wooden table, inside an open velvet box, the Sun Crystal was waiting where Mara had left it. She picked it up and placed it inside the lamp. For a moment there was silence, and then a powerful golden beam burst out across the ocean, chasing away the last storm clouds. Far below, the Silver Gull rang its bell, and Old Finn waved his hat from the deck. "Saltmere will never be dark again," said Agnes, and she wrote Mara's name in the great book of the lighthouse. Biscuit barked happily as the sun rose over the sea.